BEYOND CHIAVARI · FREE PLANNING KIT

Quinceañera Planning Kit

A 12-month plan for the Mass, the reception, the court, and the padrinos

A quinceañera is a milestone for the whole family, and every family celebrates it a little differently. Use this kit as a flexible framework: keep the traditions that matter to you, skip the ones that do not, and keep track of the many people and details along the way.

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PART 1

12-Month Timeline

Adjust the order to fit your parish, your venue, and your family's customs.

12 months out

- [ ] Sit down as a family and talk about what the quinceañera should look and feel like.
- [ ] Ask the quinceañera what matters most to her: the Mass, the dance, the dress, the food, or the party.
- [ ] Set a realistic total budget and who is contributing.
- [ ] Contact your parish about Mass dates, required classes, and any paperwork.
- [ ] Pick two or three reception dates and tour venues or banquet halls.
- [ ] Start a shared document or notebook for contacts and costs.

9 to 10 months out

- [ ] Book the reception venue and get the contract reviewed.
- [ ] Reserve the photographer and videographer.
- [ ] Book the DJ or band, and ask about a choreographer or dance coaching.
- [ ] Choose a theme, color palette, and overall style.
- [ ] Start asking padrinos or sponsors and record each commitment.
- [ ] Begin dress shopping or look for a seamstress.

6 to 8 months out

- [ ] Choose the court of honor: damas and chambelanes.
- [ ] Send the court and their families the date, rehearsal schedule, and attire details.
- [ ] Order the dress, tiara, shoes, and accessories if you have not yet.
- [ ] Choose a caterer or finalize the venue menu.
- [ ] Book the cake baker and ask about tastings.
- [ ] Start designing invitations and a tiered guest list.

4 to 5 months out

- [ ] Begin dance rehearsals for the waltz and surprise dance.
- [ ] Schedule dress fittings and court attire fittings.
- [ ] Choose decorations, centerpieces, and the head table layout.
- [ ] Order invitations and start addressing them.
- [ ] Book rentals: chairs, tables, linens, charger plates, and a dance floor if needed.
- [ ] Book hair, makeup, and transportation such as a limo or classic car.

2 to 3 months out

- [ ] Mail invitations with an RSVP date about 4 weeks before the party.
- [ ] Confirm the Mass time, readers, and music with the parish.
- [ ] Order party favors and any items for traditions your family keeps, such as the last doll.
- [ ] Finalize the program for the Mass and reception.
- [ ] Make a seating chart draft.
- [ ] Reconfirm rentals and add sparkle with uplighting or a lounge area if desired.

4 to 6 weeks out

- [ ] Track RSVPs and call people who have not replied.
- [ ] Do a full dress fitting with shoes and accessories.
- [ ] Plan the day-of schedule from hair appointment through the last dance.
- [ ] Confirm the DJ playlist, do-not-play list, and key song moments.
- [ ] Order flowers, boutonnieres, and bouquet.
- [ ] Share the schedule with the court, padrinos, and vendors.

The final week

- [ ] Give the final headcount to the venue or caterer.
- [ ] Finish the seating chart and print place cards.
- [ ] Hold a full rehearsal of the entrance and dances.
- [ ] Pack a day-of emergency kit with sewing kit, safety pins, tissues, and flat shoes.
- [ ] Confirm all arrival times and the order of events with vendors.
- [ ] Check the Chicago forecast and plan for coats, umbrellas, and parking help.

After the party

- [ ] Return rentals and attire on time.
- [ ] Send thank-you notes to guests, the court, and padrinos.
- [ ] Order prints or an album from the photographer.
- [ ] Save the dress, tiara, and keepsakes in a safe place.

PART 2

Mass and Ceremony Checklist

Every parish has its own process. Ask your priest or parish office what applies.

PARISH AND MASS

- [ ] Ask whether your parish offers a quinceañera blessing during Mass or a separate service.
- [ ] Ask about required preparation, classes, or sacramental records.
- [ ] Confirm the date, time, and length of the Mass.
- [ ] Choose readers and who will bring up the gifts.
- [ ] Pick hymns and confirm the music arrangements.
- [ ] Ask about decor rules for flowers, candles, and the processional.

ITEMS FOR THE BLESSING

- [ ] Bible or prayer book, if your family gives one.
- [ ] Rosary or medal from a godparent.
- [ ] Tiara or crown for the blessing, if your family uses it.
- [ ] Bouquet to be offered to the Virgin Mary, if that is part of your custom.
- [ ] Reserved seating for the family, padrinos, and court.

TRANSPORTATION AND PHOTOS

- [ ] Arrange arrival for the quinceañera and her court.
- [ ] Plan a photo window before or after Mass.
- [ ] Ask the photographer about church photography rules.
- [ ] Plan travel time between the church and reception.
- [ ] Account for parking and drop-off at the church.

PART 3

Padrinos and Sponsors Tracker

Padrinos (godparents or sponsors) often give or pay for a specific item. Write down who offered what so nothing gets duplicated or forgotten. Roles vary by family.

Padrino or Sponsor	Item or Role	Confirmed (Y/N)	Contact	Thank-you sent
	Cake			
	Dress or accessories			
	Tiara or crown			
	Bible or rosary			
	Photography or video			
	Bouquet or flowers			
	Music or DJ			
	Decorations			
	Favors			
	Champagne or toast drinks			
	Transportation			
	Invitations			

PART 4

Traditions Checklist

Keep what fits your family. Customs differ by country, region, and household.

COMMON RECEPTION MOMENTS

- [ ] Grand entrance of the quinceañera and her court.
- [ ] Waltz or first dance, often with her father or a chosen family member.
- [ ] Court of honor dance or choreographed surprise dance.
- [ ] Changing of shoes, from flats to heels, if your family does it.
- [ ] Last doll (ultima muñeca) presentation, if your family does it.
- [ ] Toast and a blessing from a family member.
- [ ] Cake cutting and cake service.
- [ ] Photo with each table or a family photo line.

COURT OF HONOR

- [ ] Pick damas and chambelanes, usually friends and family.
- [ ] Choose a chambelan de honor and a main escort if you wish.
- [ ] Set a rehearsal schedule that works around school.
- [ ] Share attire details, shoe sizes, and fitting dates.
- [ ] Plan thank-you gifts for the court.
- [ ] Decide where the court will sit at the reception.

PERSONAL TOUCHES

- [ ] Photo slideshow or video of her life so far.
- [ ] A message from the parents or godparents.
- [ ] Family heirloom or keepsake displayed.
- [ ] Favors that reflect her style or culture.
- [ ] A moment of recognition for grandparents and elders.

PART 5

Reception Rentals and Logistics

RENTALS

- [ ] Chairs for all guests, with cushions or covers if desired.
- [ ] Round tables of 8 to 10 for dinner seating.
- [ ] Head table or court table.
- [ ] Linens, overlays, and napkins in the chosen colors.
- [ ] Charger plates, dinnerware, and glassware if the venue does not supply them.
- [ ] Dance floor sized for the court and guests.
- [ ] Lounge furniture or a photo corner.
- [ ] Uplighting and a backdrop for photos.

LOGISTICS

- [ ] Confirm load-in and load-out times with the venue.
- [ ] Decide coat check and winter coat storage for Chicago-area cold months.
- [ ] Plan valet or parking assistance.
- [ ] Schedule the DJ and photographer arrival about 1 hour before guests.
- [ ] Assign a family helper for gifts, cards, and the guest book.
- [ ] Have a day-of coordinator or trusted family member keep the schedule.

PART 6

Budget Split

A typical starting split. Padrinos can offset some of these categories.



Category	Share	Your budget: $_____	Tip
Venue, food, and beverage	42%	$_____	Ask about per-person pricing and what is included in the package.
Dress, accessories, and hair and makeup	10%	$_____	Include alterations and a spare pair of comfortable shoes.
Photography and video	10%	$_____	Ask what is included for edited photos and the final video.
Music and entertainment	7%	$_____	Confirm dance coaching, MC services, and sound for the ceremony.
Rentals and decor	13%	$_____	Chairs, linens, dance floor, and lighting add up quickly.

Category	Share	Your budget: $_____	Tip
Cake and desserts	4%	$_____	A smaller display cake with sheet cake in the kitchen can reduce cost.
Church, flowers, and ceremony items	5%	$_____	Ask the parish about donation expectations and decor rules.
Court of honor attire and gifts	3%	$_____	Decide who pays for attire before you ask people to join.
Invitations, favors, and transportation	4%	$_____	Digital invitations plus printed formal invites for elders can save money.
Contingency	2%	$_____	Keep a cushion for alterations and last-minute needs.

PART 7

Questions to Ask Vendors

1. Can you accommodate a court dance and a surprise dance in the schedule?
2. What is included in the venue package, and what rentals do I need to add?
3. How long do we have for setup, and when must we be out?
4. Are there restrictions on candles, confetti, or balloons?
5. What is your policy on outside cake or desserts, and is there a cake-cutting fee?
6. How many hours of coverage does the photographer provide, and does that include the church?
7. Can the DJ act as a bilingual MC and play both Spanish and English music?
8. What is the deposit schedule, and what is the cancellation policy?

PART 8

Party Worksheet

QUINCEAÑERA'S NAME

MASS DATE, TIME, AND CHURCH

RECEPTION DATE AND TIME

RECEPTION VENUE AND ADDRESS

EXPECTED GUEST COUNT

COURT OF HONOR NAMES

PHOTOGRAPHER AND VIDEO CONTACT

DJ OR BAND CONTACT

CAKE BAKER AND PICKUP TIME

RENTAL COMPANY AND DELIVERY WINDOW

HAIR AND MAKEUP SCHEDULE

TOTAL BUDGET AND DEPOSITS PAID

NEXT STEP

Get every rental on one quote

Pick chairs, tables, linens, dinnerware, tents and decor from Chicago-area rental companies and see prices as you build your list at beyondchiavari.com/quote. Want a second set of eyes on your plan? Book a free planning call at beyondchiavari.com/book.

Planning rules of thumb only. Confirm counts, rules and timing with your venue and vendors. © Beyond Chiavari. Free to print and share for personal planning.